

DIAGNOSTIC WORKBOOK

Stop Planning, Start Winning

Designing strategic choices that create a
defensible competitive position

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Each worksheet is designed to be used in a leadership session — not read passively. Work through the questions with your management team, using your actual financial and operational data. The answers that are hardest to write down are the ones that matter most.

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Worksheet 2.1

Planning vs. Strategy Audit

Open your current Strategic Plan or last offsite output. Read through each goal. Classify it honestly — is it an internal operational improvement (Planning), or does it define where you compete and how you win (Strategy)?

Goal from your current plan	Planning or Strategy?	If Planning — what strategic question is it

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THE DIAGNOSIS

If every item on the list is Planning, the offsite produced a to-do list, not a strategy. The strategic questions being avoided are the ones the leadership team most needs to answer.

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Worksheet 2.2

Vision Statement Teardown

Write your current vision or strategy statement at the top. Then apply each test below. A comfortable answer is a wrong answer.

Write your current vision or strategy statement in full:

State the exact opposite of each element in your statement:

Does the opposite sound like a viable business? If not, it is an operating imperative.

What specific choice does your statement make that a rational competitor would NOT make?

This is the test of whether you have a real strategic position.

Which customers would your strategy explicitly NOT serve?

A real strategy excludes someone. If it excludes no one, it is not a strategy.

**Can your statement be falsified —
can you be wrong?**

*A strategy specific enough to be
wrong is specific enough to be
useful.*

THE DIAGNOSIS

If the opposite of every element sounds absurd, the statement is a Laudable List.
A real strategy makes a specific choice that forces a trade-off.

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Worksheet 2.3**Where to Play — 10-Point Stress Test**

For each point, answer Yes or No based on your proposed Where to Play choice. More than three No answers means the arena has not been defined specifically enough.

#	QUESTION	YES	NO	NOTES
1	Have we named a specific customer segment — not a broad industry?			
2	Have we defined a specific geography or value chain position?			
3	Is this arena one where our specific capabilities give us a structural edge?			
4	Is the arena large enough to reach Rs. 100 Cr with focused dominance?			
5	Is the arena small enough that we can realistically be the best in it?			
6	Have we named who we will NOT serve in this arena?			
7	Does this arena have structural growth drivers independent of our own effort?			
8	Can we reach the buyer in this arena through existing or buildable channels?			
9	Does the Opposite Arena represent a viable alternative for a competitor?			

10	Have we validated this arena with actual buyer conversations — not internal assumptions?			
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THE DIAGNOSIS

More than three No answers means the arena needs further refinement. An arena that cannot pass this test will generate activity without competitive advantage.

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Worksheet 2.4**How to Win — 10-Point Stress Test**

Write your proposed How to Win statement first. Then apply each test. More than three No answers means the advantage is not yet structural enough.

Your proposed How to Win statement — write it here:

Be specific. 'Quality and service' fails every test.

#	QUESTION	YES	NO	NOTES
1	Does this advantage force the buyer to choose us, or merely make us a reasonable option?			
2	Is this advantage specific and testable — not 'quality and service'?			
3	Does the Opposite Test pass? Would a rational competitor choose the opposite?			
4	Would it take a competitor more than 12 months to replicate this advantage?			
5	Does this advantage reinforce itself over time — getting stronger as we execute it?			
6	Is this advantage observable and provable to a sceptical buyer?			

7	Does this advantage allow us to charge a price premium, or reduce cost structurally?			
8	Have we named the capabilities required to deliver this advantage consistently?			
9	Have we identified the trade-offs this advantage requires us to make?			
10	Has a real buyer confirmed this advantage matters to their purchasing decision?			

THE DIAGNOSIS

A genuine How to Win is specific enough to be wrong. 'We win through superior quality' fails every test. 'We win by being the only vendor in Western India certified for food-grade stainless TIG welding with in-house NABL testing' passes.

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Worksheet 2.5

Strategic Fit Diagnostic

Bring your Where to Play and How to Win together. For each capability the strategy requires, honestly assess whether it already exists or must be built.

Must-Have Capability required	Have it? (Y/N)	If No — what does building it require?	Timeline (months)

THE DIAGNOSIS

If more than half the required capabilities must be built from scratch, the strategy is a multi-year programme, not a 12-month plan. Sequence the capability-building before committing capital to the market.

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Worksheet 2.6

Activity System Map

List every significant operational activity your business currently performs. For each, assess honestly: does this activity reinforce the strategic position, or contradict it?

Operational activity	Reinforces strategy?	Contradicts strategy?	Decision: Keep / Stop / Redesign

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THE DIAGNOSIS

If a significant operational activity does not reinforce the strategic position, it is either a legacy habit or a distraction. The discipline of the activity system is what separates a strategy that holds from one that drifts back within 12 months.

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Worksheet 2.7

The Stop-Doing Mandate

A strategy is defined as much by what it refuses to do as by what it chooses to do. This is the hardest worksheet in the series. If nothing painful can be written here, the strategy has not been made yet.

What customer segment will we stop actively pursuing?

Name it specifically. 'Low-margin customers' is not specific enough.

What product category or service will we phase out?

Give a timeline — when will the last order be accepted?

What sales channel or geography will we exit?

What internal process will we stop doing because it contradicts the strategy?

What is the estimated Rs. value of revenue we will deliberately walk away from in Year 1?

If this number is zero, the trade-off has not been made.

THE DIAGNOSIS

The revenue in the last row is the price of the strategy. If no revenue is being walked away from, the strategy has not made a real choice. The most expensive mistake in manufacturing strategy is trying to serve everyone.

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Worksheet 2.8

Choice Cascade Map

Map your strategy across all five levels. Each level must be consistent with every other level. An inconsistency at any level collapses the strategy.

**WINNING
ASPIRATION**

*What does winning look like for us?
What specific outcome for which
specific customer?*

WHERE TO PLAY

*Which specific segment, geography,
or value chain position have we
chosen?*

HOW TO WIN

*What specific, uncopyable
advantage forces buyers to choose
us over every competitor?*

**MUST-HAVE
CAPABILITIES**

*What must we build — equipment,
talent, process, knowledge — to make
the advantage real?*

**MANAGEMENT
SYSTEMS**

*What KPIs, incentive structures, and
daily rhythms enforce the strategy on
the factory floor?*

THE DIAGNOSIS

Each level must reinforce every other level. If the Management Systems still measure machine utilisation and volume while the strategy requires premium positioning, the strategy will die within 90 days of launch.

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Worksheet 2.9

Strategy Vulnerability Test

Apply each stress scenario to your strategy. For each, identify the exact point of collapse and the specific mitigation. Do not leave any row blank.

If your single most important customer cancelled their contract tomorrow, what happens?

Describe the exact financial and operational consequence.

If your biggest competitor copied your How to Win exactly, what would you do?

If raw material prices increased 30% overnight, does the strategy still work?

If the founding team left, could the strategy be executed by the next management layer?

**What single external change —
regulatory, technological, or market
— would invalidate the strategy?**

Name it specifically.

THE DIAGNOSIS

A strategy that cannot survive this test has not been stress-tested. The vulnerabilities identified here become the input to the thin-slicing experiments in Book Three.

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Worksheet 2.10

Assumption Map

List every significant assumption the strategy depends on. Classify each by confidence level and criticality. The Kill Zone assumptions must be tested before any capital is committed.

Strategic assumption	Confidence (H/M/L)	Criticality if wrong (H/M/L)	How to test it cheaply and

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THE DIAGNOSIS

The assumptions that are Low Confidence and High Criticality are the Kill Zone. These must be tested before any capital is committed. Everything else is secondary.

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The diagnostic questions in this workbook are designed to be worked through in a leadership session. The answers that are hardest to write down — the ones that require looking at actual data rather than intuition — are the ones that matter most.

If working through these worksheets has surfaced a strategic question your leadership team cannot yet answer clearly — about where to compete, how to invest, or what to test before committing capital — that question is where the advisory work begins.

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